

User, You're Just Playing the Game: How *WarGames*, *The Social Network* and *The Matrix* Depict Digital Power

What if the true history of power is not recorded in elections and wars, but in glowing monitors and logins? This paper examines the influence of digital technologies on our perception of power. By analysing *WarGames* (1983), *The Social Network* (2010), and *The Matrix* (1999), I show how these films depict new forms of digital authority and illustrate how technology redefines who controls society and how this control operates. I mainly focus on how cinematography, storytelling, and character interactions represent these shifting power dynamics.

From the moment *WarGames* begins, it quickly becomes clear that it is far from a typical teen film. Beneath the surface of school corridors and family scenes, a high-stakes technological underground pulses. Blinking lights, mainframes, and massive terminals guard nuclear missiles. David, the main character, accidentally accesses the command system and thinks he is only hacking for fun. However, he activates a war protocol and a simulated countdown to a Russian attack. The bunker's digital world feels tangible and raw: green code flashes on shadowy screens, wireframe maps pulse with danger, and apparently secure rooms groan under the weight of machinery. But how safe can anything truly be if a bored teenager can break in from his bedroom?

The real tension lies not in the countdown itself, but in who gets to decide: humans or machines? Set during the Cold War, the military relies on the system for certainty in the event of potential conflict. Computers quietly become arbiters of life and death. This turn becomes explicit when Dr Falken, the system's programmer, appeals to General Beringer: "... you're listening to a machine. Do the world a favour and don't act like one." The line highlights the film's core anxiety: what happens when we stop questioning our machines and let them decide the course of action?

The tension rises once more in the iconic tic-tac-toe sequence as the program gradually gains control of the war scenario. By playing the game to exhaustion, the supercomputer reaches its upsetting conclusion: "The only winning move is not to play."

To me, this ending suggests a shift in strategic thinking from humans to machines. This sense of

apprehension sets the stage for the next transition: digital systems leaving government bunkers and infiltrating everyday life—a shift powerfully explored in *The Social Network*.

Set in the early 2000s at Harvard, as digital technologies intertwine with daily life, *The Social Network* reveals a campus dominated by capitalism and status, bathed in low-key lighting and muted colours, predominantly denatured yellow and blue. This environment reflects the main character, Mark Zuckerberg, an ambitious student who uses his computer to create Facemash and then Facebook as his own *club*. Lines of code typed in the middle of the night are enough to reshape social structures and relationships. While *WarGames* warns of the state ceding power to machines, *The Social Network* shows how Facebook becomes a space where hierarchies are negotiated: the platform organises who appears, who attracts attention, and who remains on the margins. I would argue that this creates an evident duality in the film's social world.

On one side, there is the Old Money, represented by the Winklevoss twins and the legal system. Insisting on traditional rules and manners, they move through wood-panelled rooms in well-tailored suits, appearing somehow outdated. Moreover, they symbolise an elite based on heritage and social status. On the other side, there are the new disruptors, led by Mark and Sean Parker. They dismiss traditional formalities as superficial, instead focusing on a new form of social validation based on visibility and engagement. Sean Parker captures this shift when he declares, “We lived on farms, then we lived in cities, and now we’re going to live on the internet.”

By designing the platform's architecture, Mark does not merely create a product; he transforms social life. He decides what counts as a “connection” and how visibility is measured, turning code into a tool for rewriting the rules of the world that excluded him. In this sense, *The Social Network* is the central point of the trilogy: the moment when the digital stops being a specialised tool and becomes infrastructure—something we live within without much thought.

This concept of digital power reaches its zenith in *The Matrix*. Set in a future where machines have taken control, human bodies are harvested for energy while people's minds are kept in a digital simulation called the Matrix. If *WarGames* hands strategic calculation to machines and *The Social Network* hands social recognition to platforms, *The Matrix* hands reality itself to AI. Here, authority functions by controlling what people see and feel, and the Agents exemplify this surveillance and control: they can inhabit anyone and “guard all the doors” of the system. From a visual perspective, the film's style makes this power especially evident. Inside the Matrix, the image has a green tint reminiscent of computer code. This world feels quiet and familiar to its inhabitants. Yet, it increasingly appears trapped and rehearsed, both for the audience and for Neo, the heroic character, who starts with only a feeling of discomfort. Morpheus, Neo's mentor, describes the Matrix as “a prison for your mind” and offers Neo the red pill. In this pivotal scene, mirrors ripple, and the green

world disintegrates as Neo wakes in the real world. Outside the Matrix, colours are faded, making the real dimension seem decayed and brutal. In the simulated reality, the déjà-vu black cat scene is decisive for me: twice walking by when the code changes, the cat's presence reveals the system's fragility to Neo. Eventually, he begins to see the flaws in the virtual world he once took for granted as real. Moreover, the stylised bullet-time sequences slow the film's action and suggest that the system's rules are not absolute, allowing Neo to resist the AI from within. In the final confrontation, Neo perceives bullets and Agents as streams of code and halts them with a single "No". In my view, this suggests that free will and power might belong to those who can awaken and rewrite the system.

To sum up, these three films demonstrate a growing escalation in digital power. *WarGames* presents computers as specialised tools that serve and sometimes challenge state authority. *The Social Network* illustrates the next stage, where platforms like Facebook redefine social life and shift power to those who design and control digital infrastructures. *The Matrix* then takes this logic to its extreme: artificial systems shape reality so profoundly that stepping outside them seems nearly impossible. For me, the troubling question is how much independence we still have when our screens quietly dictate what we see, remember, and desire—are we truly choosing to play, or are we just following rules that were written for us?